



The SNELL FIELD GUIDE
to

**DISAPPEARING ACTS
for
GIRLS & GIRAFFES**

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Cover Image: Clay, Cosack & Co. Lithography. “*A Living Giraffe in P.T. Barnum’s Great Zoological Collection*”. 1876. Ringling Museum, Tibbals Circus Collection. (edited)

Chp. Images (blue): A. Schmidt’s *Atlas der Diatomaceenkunde* (1890)

Chp. Images (green): R.B. Hough’s *The American Woods* (1888)

CHARACTERS.



ANNA (STAGE NAME, ANASTASIA),
Fourth-seat Equestrienne.

CROWLEY,
Menagerie Superintendent (and conman).

MARTHA,
Twin sister to Anna.

THOMAS,
Martha’s son (whom the town believes is Anna’s).

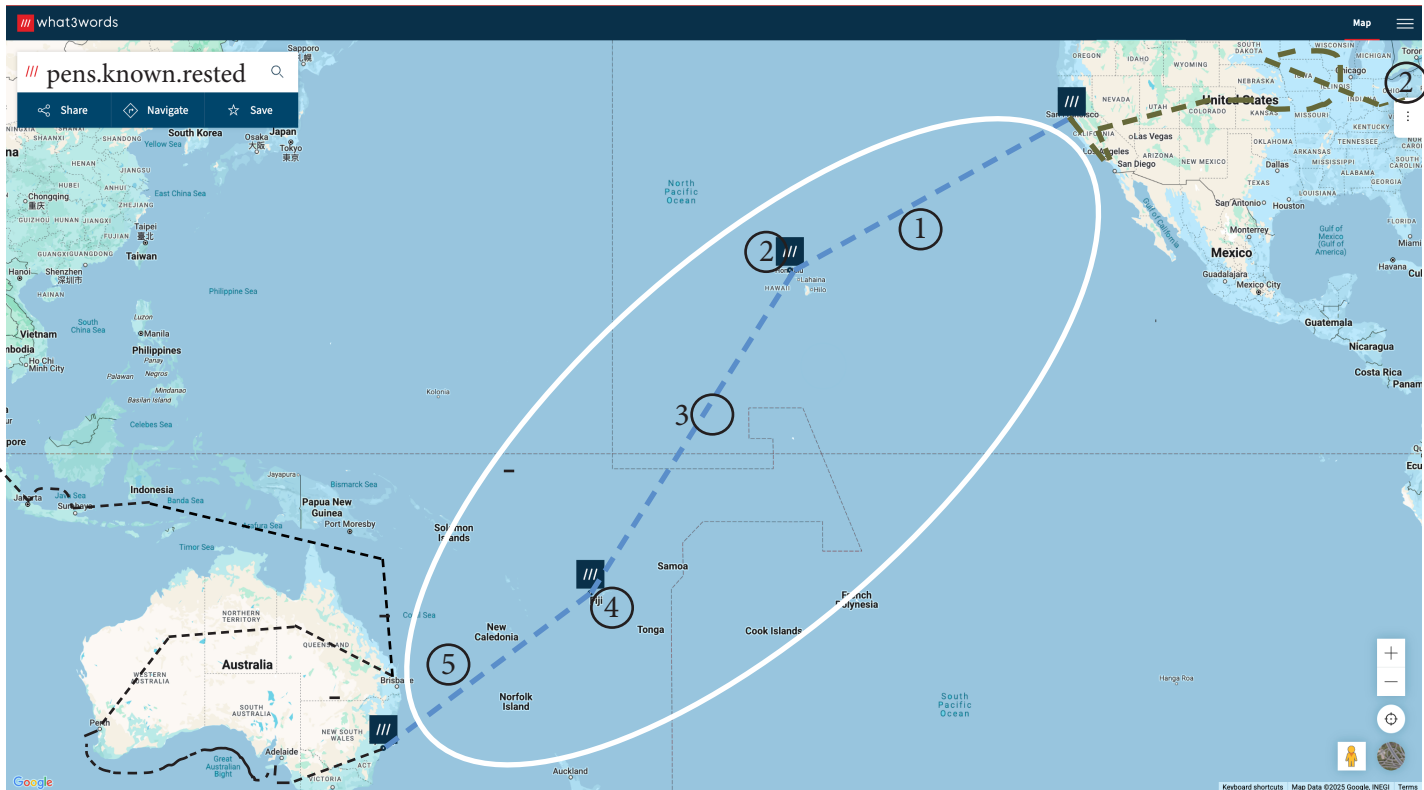
PAULINE,
Acrobat member of the Company.

(M)APPS.



Route Map 1

App Guide 42



In 1876, the Cooper & Bailey Circus traveled west from St. Louis to San Francisco. Arriving on the west coast, they set sail for Australia, stopping in Hawaii first, then Fiji. On board was a large menagerie of animals, several of whom died in rough waters near the Coral Sea. They left the remaining animals to winter in Sydney and toured with a reduced company through what was then known as the Dutch Indies on their way to India.

1

ANNA/STASIA GETS ON BOARD.

If you're in the living room, reading a book, the living room tends to disappear. But you are walking at the edge of the water. Move your screen up to the Boat-house sign. Keep it in your vision. Follow the camera east, to your left. Take this sidewalk to the park entrance then turn right onto the path.

[Phone-in-hand]



The river leads to Narragansett Bay, then on to the Atlantic Ocean. To get to the Pacific in 1876 - where

[Phone-in-hand] [W3W Map-App]



Anna is swimming, waiting, where the Panama Canal hasn't been carved into history yet - it takes over a month to get from this spot, down the east coast of South America, and at last around the headland of Cape Horn, at the tip of Chile.

If it helps, you can just think of the ocean as one, singular place - where Anna is diving - deeper and deeper, until a small, sharp corner of fear starts a snag at her stomach and she flips back toward the surface, exhaling steadily - letting her breath melt through the fear's tight heat sparkling between her blood and her skin.

[Both Second-Screens Disappear]

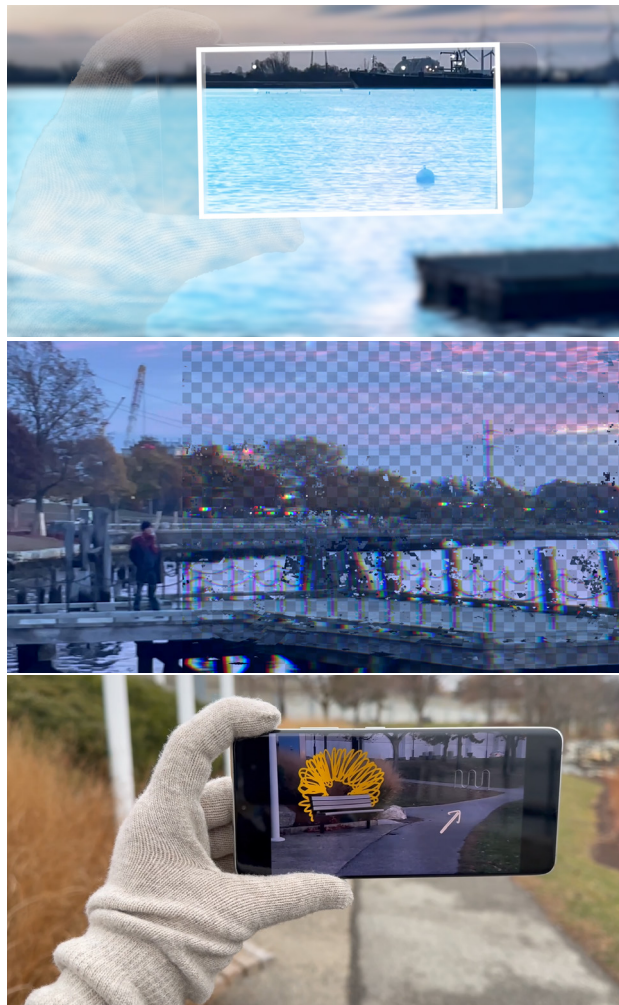
Pauline taught her how the acrobats pull their minds in sync with an exhale - moving thoughts from the jaw down; teeth unclenched, shoulders (down), balls of her feet (in line with) your toes (pointed).

After a minute floating on her back she dives back down, tracking her depth with glimpses back to the spotlight shrinking on the surface.

[Phone-in-Hand]

After three days spent rocking between seasick self-loathing and seasick boredom camera wave, Anna set out, determined to explore every bit of ship outside her cabin.

Head towards that bike rack. We'll get closer to the water from the pier. Earlier than any fishermen,



but someone is still here.

Crossing paths with Fritz in a third, obscure corner, Anna offered up a conspiratorial smirk.

[Black-and-White film] [Translate App]

(subtitles)

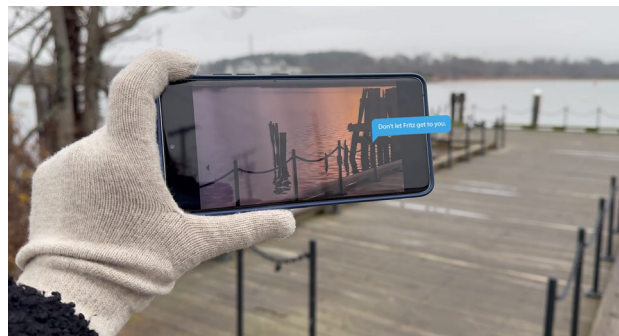
- *We meet again!*
- *Because I can't find goddamn Crowley anywhere - and I know for sure now he's been shorting the pot.*
- *Oh, right... Have you seen anything good on the ship though? Found anything interesting?*
- *All you girls want to do is gossip! Listen Anastasia, if you see Crowley, tell him I'm looking for him. Got that? Or actually - don't!*

[Phone-in-Hand] [Text Message]

Don't let Fritz get to you.

[Phone-in-Hand]

They were five days out when she had dodged the dawn-guard sailors and slipped silently into the water while the ship was still sleeping. Underwater, she found the last moon's spotlight gliding along the surface over her head. It played barely-there light as she moved, warping and waving with invisible, impossible geometry until, at some perfectly aligned angle, the giraffe at last slid into Anna's mind all in one image. Then blinked out of comprehension again just



just as quickly.

The question of the giraffe had been bothering her since the two had crossed paths in San Francisco on the dock waiting to embark. Not one to swoon, Anna nonetheless felt a gentle tug in that direction when she met the giraffe -

[Phone-in-Hand] [NightSky App]

- when she stretched her neck as far back as she could and found she was still unable to collect the whole animal in her mind's eye. She had tried instead to build an understanding piece by piece - starting with what she recognized. Four hooves yes, of course, like any horse. The legs would have to be skipped for now. It was no use - they were spindly and their markings didn't seem properly attached. She kept catching them drifting in the corner of her eye.

[Second-Screens Disappear]

Its tail was, thankfully, spotless, and though its tufted end seemed a little more scraggly than she had somehow expected, it was recognizable. She jumped past the neck, to its ears, which were sweet - friendly somehow. They sat on either side of patient eyes with long lashes that convinced Anna she was meeting some kindred spirit.

Landing on this characterization, the spots held steady [giraffe spots on rocks] and she could glide her sight smoothly down its confusing neck. Still, in



Anna's mind, the different parts just wouldn't puzzle-piece together.

That morning, from underneath the water, she thought she had found it and the relief buoyed her up, like skipping high after a stone - at last! - leaves your shoe. When the sense of the creature came apart again, she felt the sense of her own self diluted somehow.

[Phone-in-Hand]

The next morning Anna tried again to sneak into the water before sun. Two deckhands stopped her and she tried pouting first, then demanded: She was a lady and could do as she pleased!

How much trouble did she hold in her small frame? Without needing to confer, they mimed vague misunderstanding, but stayed until Anna turned and awkwardly headed back to her cabin. The look on their faces had shamed her, but she left without an apology, telling herself it was smoother to drop the whole scene. She didn't swim again before Honolulu.

[Second-Screens Disappear]

That night, she dreamt in all blues, so waking was a plug pulled on the whole ocean.



[\[VIDEO LINK\]](#)

NUNS & OTHER PROBLEMS.

On the eighth day, the ship docked at Honolulu with everyone shouting “land ho!” and throwing jigs on wobbling land legs. Hotel rooms were reserved for top acts. This meant that during their night in Honolulu, most of the company never fully shook the sensation of waves moving through their bodies, even as they flew through the air. Crowley stayed on board where he complained with the others, but in a careless, social sort of way. At the *One & Only!* show on the island, he was standing in as equestrian manager, urging the fourth equestrienne to ride faster, but Anastasia was moving with deep ocean in her bones and he relented when he noticed the shimmery effect of it.

Crowley instinctively understood the illusion at the heart of the circus. He himself had spent years perfecting the parlor trick of his forgettable appearance. He didn't seem particularly tall, or short, but would wear lifts from time to time so that his height was ultimately unknown. His head was topped with brown hair, looking darker or lighter depending on the sun and sometimes sporting a chalked white at his temples. He wore a beard, and shaved it when he thought a fresher face (or a change in description) would be useful. His accent was completely unplaceable, gently mirroring his interlocutors and setting that at a subconscious ease. With a little social effort,

he was good looking enough for a man to be charming, but a pivot to quiet made him almost invisible. Until Philadelphia, this flexibility had allowed him to survive comfortably on minor, not-quite-cons. He had smuggled himself out of Pennsylvania under the tent, and was shakily grateful at the time, but as the distance grew, his confidence returned.

Their route was designed to coincide with the Hawaiian King's birthday and - hoping to make the most of the generous, holiday spirit - Crowley kept the Giraffe and the other exotics on the main deck even after their seven days at sea, so that locals had to hand over twenty-five cents to ogle his menagerie up close. The passers-by couldn't see much for free from the shore. In the open air of the main deck, he was pleased with himself, seeing how the Giraffe's lovely neck shaped a dramatic fourth mast. Then came the ceremonial gunshots, followed by celebratory gunshots, and the animals' anxieties vibrated them into an unpredictable state. Finally, the Giraffe slid its nick down and over the side, ready to jump and Crowley reluctantly brought the menagerie down to land, ending his ticket sales early and stirring up grumbles among those who had already paid.

Back on solid ground, the Giraffe maintained an easy, aloof sort of grace - even as it released a stream of surprisingly pebble-like shit onto the well-

trodden hay cover. But when the trees overhead bounced their branches, the Giraffe dipped its head in a flinch - a phantom threat from the cargo hold's ceiling would dangle over its ossicones for the rest of its life. Anastasia stood nearby and Crowley watched as she mirrored this infrequent, broken movement until her eyes seemed to relax inward. Crowley wondered if she was drunk.

He knew everything that happened in the company and kept their secrets until he could use them. So he knew Anastasia had discovered getting drunk earlier on in the route, outside Chicago, and then spent her free time in Wisconsin and much of Minnesota fairly well sloshed and egged on by the canvas men, who waited, closeby, like sharks. He knew that by Dakota Territory she had kept to a flask and to herself.

He also knew the scandal she was smuggling out of town, hoping to leave her twin sister with only its dissipating dregs. When Anna had joined the troupe six months ago in Zanesville (becoming *the elegant, the amazing* - Anastasia!), he hadn't had to ask around much. People were eager to talk about Anna's latest disgrace. After growing up with the good nuns at the orphanage - whose discipline she never *was* grateful for - she had managed to get herself pregnant. Who knew *who* the father was. Her sister, Martha - who always *was* the good one and who had wedding *just*

around the corner, *poor girl* - was dragged into her mess. Crowley immediately saw through the girls' con. The twins had spent months living in each other's identities, so that Martha could have her child without demolishing her reputation or ending her engagement. As for Anna, she got to leave the town. There were little trip-ups of course, both girls tended to turn their heads to both names. And Martha's fiancé needed constant reassurance that her absence was temporary, only through her sister's difficult time. The first was redaily ignorable as twin-mystery, and eventually the fiance only thought Anna-as-Martha more saintly for her quiet, tired devotion. Crowley was impressed - it was a plan that he deemed both simple and brutal. So, before Anna reached the point in her pitch where she lied about knowing how to ride, Crowley had waved his hand in her direction and told Cooper, "We'll probably lose a girl by California anyway."

What Crowley didn't know was that the night before Anna had left, Martha had turned to Anna with their now constant whisper. She wasn't ready to break their plan open, but guiltily tested it with a soft prick. *Maybe this is crazy. Maybe Anna should stay, live here, with Martha and Thomas.*

Both girls were buzzing from the fear in these final hours - but Martha's fear was tinged with guilt and

Anna's was growing claustrophobic with resentment. Anytime Martha-as-Anna was shunned or pitied or scolded on the street, Anna-as-Martha felt it, and its opposite - the relief and the lightness. If Anna-as-Martha was encouraged or praised for her generosity with the shamefully pregnant Martha-as-Anna, she suppressed a painful cringe and a warm glow of appreciation. By the time Thomas was born, when they could drop the ruse and return to themselves again, neither girl kept all of themselves.

California was a fantasy of freedom and the circus bringing her there formed a sort of mirrored fantasy, amplifying the idea to the seemingly infinite. By Colorado, Anna sensed, rather than knew, where this was true, or not true - like feeling rather than seeing the worn parts of fabric on her costume. She had escaped with an asterisk. Her body snatched long moments of unqualified freedom riding along the perimeter of center stage. But when the people who gathered on the stands lost their individuality, when they merged into *The Crowd*, she felt herself at the periphery of a world that excluded her, and still needed her at their shores to mark the start of an unfathomable abyss. California grew nearer and more watered down.

Martha and Anna had actually been born there. Before their father brought them back east and died, leaving them with the nuns and a mess of other

'Children of the Battlefield.' When the nuns trotted out the noble battlefield's children for charity, they would tell their father's story through a sighing litany of forgivable sins and well-known tragedies - every line starting with a weary, Christian, all-knowing 'of course'.

"Of course dragging his two girls all the way to California on the promise of gold was simply weakness to greed."

"Of course, it really was no place for children."

"Of course he only found failure - and finally the good sense to give it up."

"Of course, that only brought him back to civilization in time for the war (sigh) poor man."

"He found decent work for the telegraph company, but of course, that was snapped up by the army faster than the devil can fly."

"Of course, it was just as dangerous laying wire as it was in battle."

The girls called them *Sisters of the Holy Course*, or just, *The Sisters of Course*. Later on though, when Martha was engaged to be wed in that church, Anna brought up their old joke and was chastised by her sister. She fumbled around for sympathy and almost grasped some, thinking of the nuns as being young girls themselves once; as being mostly ignored now, something like only half-women. Unfortunately, this

last thought triggered a quick damming of empathy. It pulled to the surface the image of Sister Barbara, standing Anna in the garbage bin, after tearing her from her bed where she had been caught with a small mirror angled between her legs. Then cries to St. Mary Magdalene for penitence, then, the Sister's knobby finger. "You're nothing but trash. Say it."

After that day, the nuns assigned the sisters more womanly tasks, demanding they focus on the younger children, good sense, and decent work. Anna never quite forgave Martha for being good at it. Either way, the army didn't pay any severance to the line layers so when their father died, the sisters were stashed, broke, with the nuns who accepted donations on their behalf - on behalf of all the worthy poor.

3
OPTICAL ILLUSIONS.

INT. CAR, BACKSEAT

- Anna, Right?

- Yeah. Thanks for the lift.

[Rideshare Screen] [Shazam App]



Leaving Honolulu, the days onboard had pitched stir-crazy, and the men had taken to tying company members to their chairs when they were caught napping. It had become raucous, nonstop sport. The women, omitted from this ritual, were left to talk that sharpened, then dulled, repelling people, then easing them back together.

[Rideshare Screen] [Sky Bubbles]

During one of the sharper eras, Anna slips into a corner of the raised deck at the stern (above the busier main deck) and practices softening time - coaxing her vision to disappear the horizon or convincing her senses that the boat was still and only the world turned. Under this slackened gaze, the sky's white became bird feather and bones that dripped into the waves' crests and wakes. Along an electric sparkle line it transformed - *abracadabra!* - blue, seeping down into jay then whale.

[Rideshare Screen] [Transparency Bubbles]

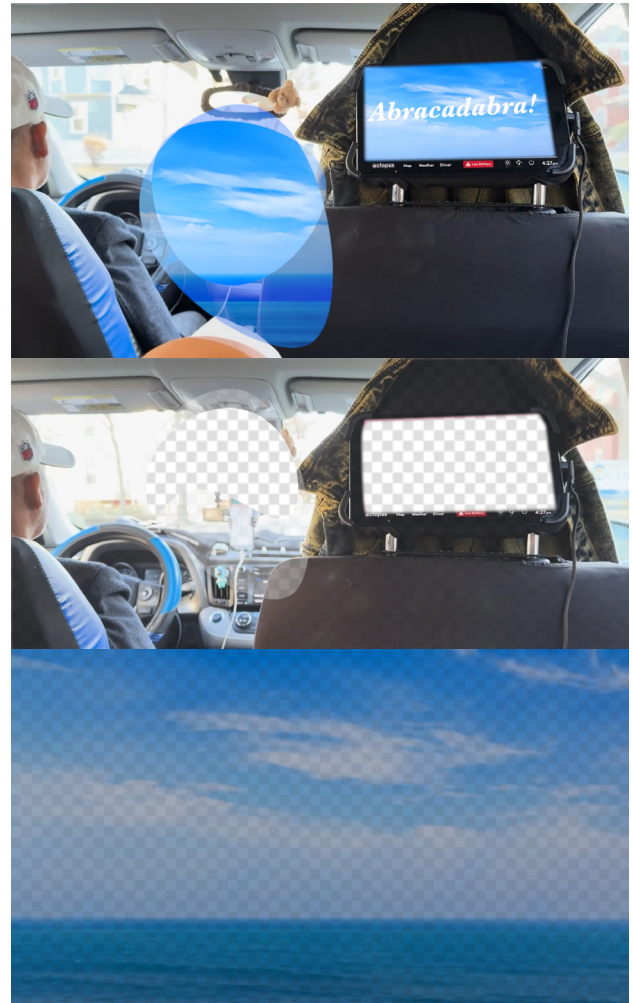
Taken together these illusions made a single laboratory - where she sat, experimenting with her tricks until she could feel a bubble of weightlessness begin to rise in her mind - so close to nothing that she could almost disappear from herself.

The equator was drawn into existence over a hundred years before this ship had been built, and the calendar long before that.

[Both Second-Screens Disappear]

So there was no accounting for it when the day disappeared. Dawn had wavered a bit at its breaking then, when no one was looking, the whole day winked out.

[Personal Trail Cam] [Animal Trail Cam]



[Personal Trail Cam] [Animal Trail Cam]

The captain thought his calendar was off, but then the ship's records were too. The infirmary, kitchen, and the cargo hold all froze, waiting for someone else to resolve the same issue.

[Animal Trail Cam]

The passengers pooled their confusion until it swayed on the brink of panic. When land came into view it was frightening, but it still brought the relief of a tangible reality with it. There was nothing else to be done so, for the most part, people swallowed hard, pushed the fear down and cemented it there with stiff drink.

[Security Split Screen Trail Cams]

Some children continued to wipe at their noses, still tender in the uncomfortable atmosphere of an unseen, unknown, and shapeless fear. Anna lay low. More than a few people disembarked early at Apia, and waited for the next steamer, but no one's letters mentioned the day that disappeared and no one spoke of it much further - on the off chance it was only their own demons, or on a different off chance that its name could resurrect it.

In the midst of the ship's collective fog, Anna's ear caught on something interesting. The ship's skeleton night crew changes shift at 4:45am. The next day, she floated off into the ocean again, sneaking out in the



almost-dawn to find the small ladder behind a lifeboat towards the ship's stern while her bunk mates slept and the horizon had only just begun to glow.

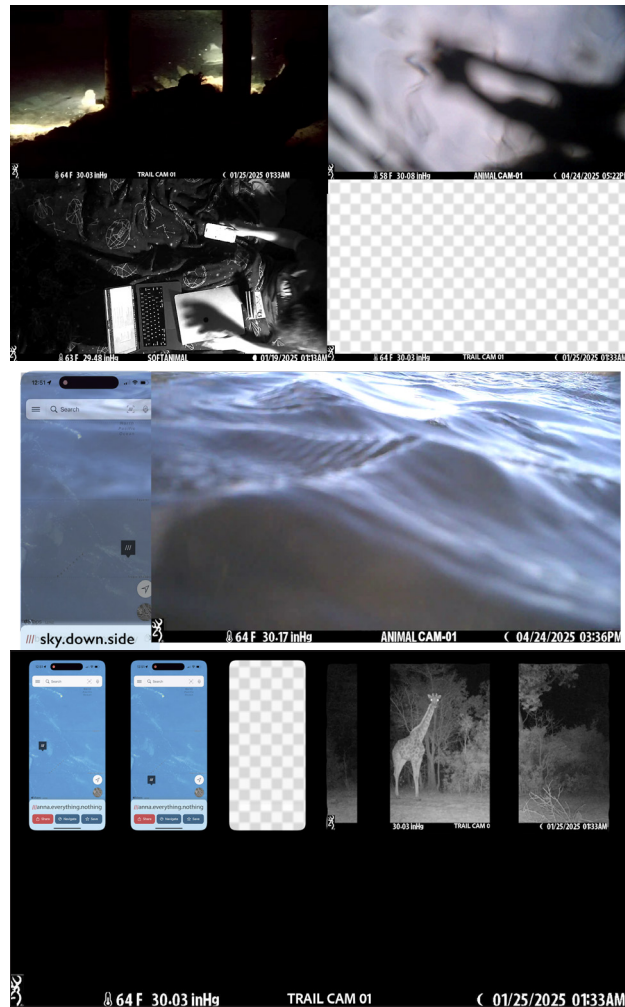
[What3Words App] [Trail Cam]

Again, Anna dove until fear caught up. Then back up towards the sky, then down again through the strange border where she was Anastasia on one side and Anna and everything and nothing on the other.

[What3Words App] [Trail Cam]

The loudest sound was breath and it slows time. She no longer checked in at jaws, shoulders, arms, feet. She discovers that her breath can be slower still or not at all, listening to the muffled sounds of the ocean's movement - they came from, into, and through her. The ossified time on the ship was a resin building, tightening around her. The slowness underwater had the opposite effect. The Giraffe came along in her mind, swimming beside her as an unlikely ocean mascot, but one that ran counter to logic in a way she liked; a warm sensation of spice somewhere over her favorite neurons.

When she poured herself back onto deck she came face to face with a crewman who forgot everything with a combination of flirt and bribe. Ninth day, tenth day... time spent in the ocean was less substantial and she had semi-dissolved into a similar state. Until she



more, not ready to let go of the feeling.

[Animal Trail Cam]

After turning the sky over heels this one, last time, she glimpsed an odd line over her shoulder, in her shrinking spotlight. It wandered out at a cross angle to the wide ripples of the ship's subtle wake. A sudden question bubbled, baiting her to swim out, instead of down, to trace this line from underneath the surface. She obeyed and dropped the discipline in her muscles, waving away from harpoon to the smooth slink of fish. She followed the wire like until she eventually came across the tail end of things.

[Rideshare Screens]

This time, when Anna pulled herself up from the ladder's last rung, she dripped her ocean straight onto the toes of Crowley, towering over her with his left eyebrow higher still. She tried tears - Anna herself surprised at their authenticity but he only held up his hand then motioned her to follow him to the menagerie's cargo hold.



[\[VIDEO LINK\]](#)

QUESTIONS & ANSWERS ABOUT GIRAFFES

[The following is a partial transcript of a ticketed lecture presented on board by Prof. W.G. Crowley, and recovered from the trunk of missing passenger, Anna Miller.]

The question of the giraffe only ever calls up more questions - baffling the scientific community for

[...Illegible...]

surprising though I assure you entirely grounded in biological facts that I shall present to you all this evening.

The central focus of my study has been posthumous, that is to say, through the autopsy of the giraffe [...Illegible...] As such, I feel I must apologize to any ladies in the audience

[...Illegible...]

We see these creatures as aloof, perhaps peaceful.

[...Illegible...] though not trained in the biology and zoology of the african continent, have undoubtedly recognized these qualities in the giraffe's gaze and demeanor. What is it that we should make of this seeming melancholia?

After years of studying these specimens I have developed my own theory [...Illegible...]

CONT.

It is not melancholia or peacefulness - but rather an excessive secrecy.

[...Illegible...] same number of vertebrae as humans suggesting some distant [...Illegible...]

The African is also known for their elusive nature and there is some weight to the notion that [...Illegible...]

though further research

[...Illegible...]

environment and ecology.

[...Illegible...] thought to be mute [...Illegible...] between creatures, communication can be observed in subtle twitches from their protrusions [...Illegible...] neither ears nor horns. [...Illegible...]

[...Illegible...] secret codes like human whispers though vocal chords show no sign of [...Illegible...]

[DIAGRAM]

[...Illegible...] knees that don't allow for sitting or crouching without one leg extended

[...Illegible...]

[...Illegible...][...Illegible...]

[A. Miller's Note: During the lecture, two ladies fainted and several audience members had ceased believing in the existence of giraffes all together.]

CHEERS TO KANDAVU!

In each town, spectators were invited to bet 5 cents on the Giraffe's name. The winner would be announced to applause and invited into the ring to collect the pot, along with a poster of the Giraffe and a life of bragging rights. In each town, Crowley picked a name from the bets at random, inked it beneath the Giraffe's image, and pocketed half the pot so that the Giraffe had as many names as stops on the route. At first, this had depressed Anna, in the strangely deep, heavy way mundane injustices do, and she had spent a good portion of her conscious and unconscious thought on trying to find one she felt was right, one between just them at least. After Honolulu, she had thought she might track the answer in her dreams, or in the space just before them when the waves still in her body moved in syncopation with reality. This had the benefit of making her nightmares and dreams equally interesting, but nights passed with the giraffe still unknown, and then waking reality would drop like a pebble into the puddle of her consciousness sending sleep's phantasmagoria rippling over her eyelids. She stayed under though, trying to hold the Giraffe loosely in diluted thoughts, while she waited for the last of sleep to get off her chest. Clipped to the metal of her cot's frame was a scribbled list:, Eleanor, Paprika, Surabaya ...

After the day that disappeared, Anastasia had a

new idea for the Giraffe. It wasn't suffering from namelessness at all. Its name was allowed to disappear in the sea of too many names. All the days it spent being gawked at, posed, paraded, and under constant surveillance were suddenly colored with a moment's reprieve, the dignity of privacy. In Fiji, the Giraffe was almost 'Kandavu'. Crowley had already written it on the poster, when Anastasia appeared at his side.

Kandavu is the name of this town.

Which town?

This one - the one we're in now. I imagine the people here are unlikely to believe that a Giraffe from San Francisco shares their town's name.

Goddamnit.

He grumbled, but took out a new poster. Without thinking, Anna rolled up his first draft, tucked it under her arm, and disappeared. He let her.

By now, the two had a comfortable enough collusion. When Crowley found Anastasia returning from her illegal swim holding his waxed canvas bag he decided it was time to cash in on all of Anastasia's secrets. In the menagerie's cargo hold, he had shown her a hatch that was opened on a given schedule to ventilate the animals' area and through which she

could drop a ladder and continue her swims. These swims would now periodically include a small float tethered to her ankle for the delivery of gold or opium to designated local, smaller boats that wouldn't be checked at the port when the steamship arrived.

Crowley's show-business magnanimity was so well practiced at this point, that Anna accepted her new role with gratitude. When he mentioned sending something extra to her sister, Martha, and her sister's child, Anna felt the resurgence of this life-altering secret. She hadn't realized it had disappeared into an invisible background without having to guard it - but instead of the anxiety she had known in Zanesville, Crowley's winking knowledge made Martha suddenly appear before her and Anna was grateful for that too.

The rumors about Anastasia had formed a vague cloud of conspiracy that trailed her wherever she went. It started in the usual place - she was sleeping with the menagerie manager, or some canvas man, or one of the Chinese sailors on board. She was pregnant, then heartbroken, then sick from abortifacients, then sea-mad. A sea-witch. The ship's doctor proposed mal de débarquement syndrome. None of these diffuse theories could stick. Anna herself had become watery around her edges. Among the troupe, it soon became a sort of parlor game to concoct elaborate backstories for her. Her life seemed to hold the

form of any story's vessel. So when she put the Giraffe's poster on the wall next to her bunk, it only ignited the fun:

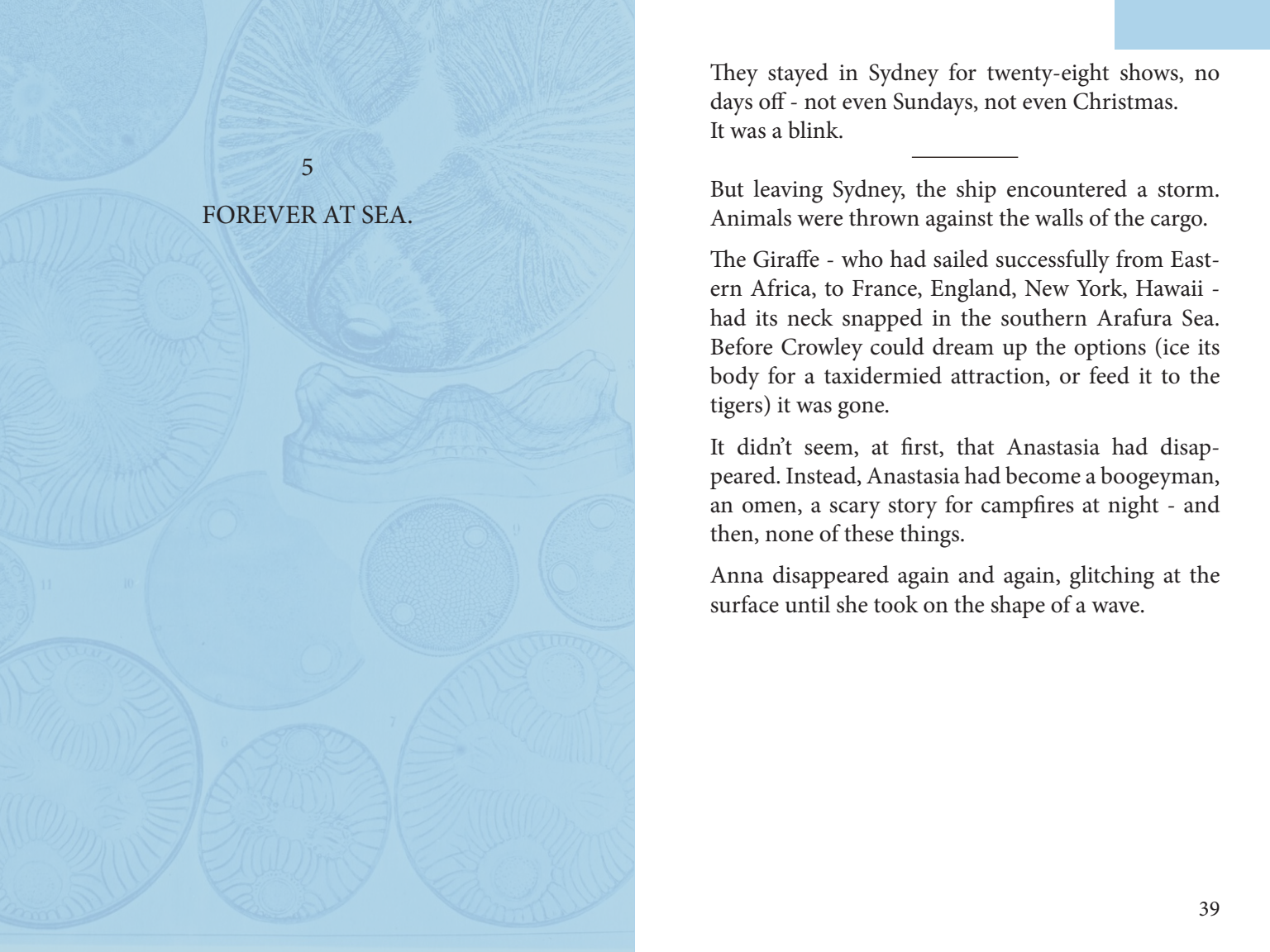
Anastasia had been in Fiji to murder a cotton plantation owner who had stolen her inheritance during the war.

She was a rebel spy, now on the run.

She was leaving to take her vows at the convent.

She was heading to Australia to try her luck in their gold rush.

She was part shark or a mermaid or alien shapeshifter escaping government surveillance.



5

FOREVER AT SEA.

They stayed in Sydney for twenty-eight shows, no days off - not even Sundays, not even Christmas. It was a blink.

But leaving Sydney, the ship encountered a storm. Animals were thrown against the walls of the cargo.

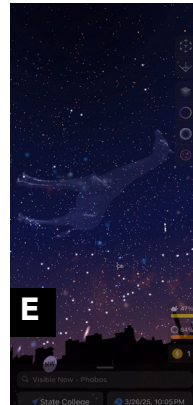
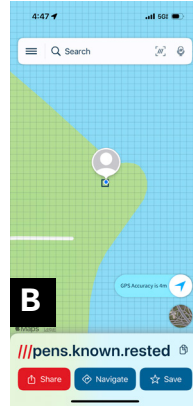
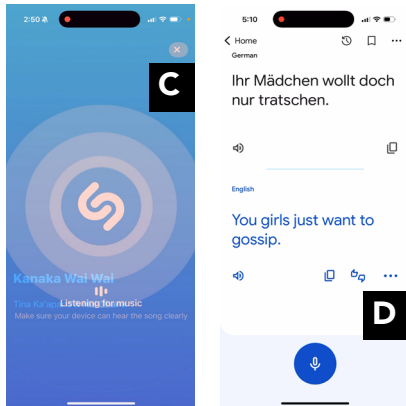
The Giraffe - who had sailed successfully from Eastern Africa, to France, England, New York, Hawaii - had its neck snapped in the southern Arafura Sea. Before Crowley could dream up the options (ice its body for a taxidermied attraction, or feed it to the tigers) it was gone.

It didn't seem, at first, that Anastasia had disappeared. Instead, Anastasia had become a boogeyman, an omen, a scary story for campfires at night - and then, none of these things.

Anna disappeared again and again, glitching at the surface until she took on the shape of a wave.



APP GUIDE. (AUGMENTING REALITY)



A Not an app, per se, but a choreographed or otherwise altered video captured at 3x can be aligned to its real-world scene locations and create a low tech augmented reality experience. (Inspired by Cardiff & Miller*)

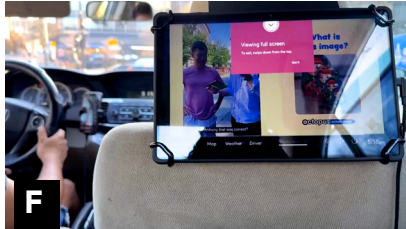
B What3Words is a mapping app that provides unique ids in the form of 3 randomly concatenated words for every 3 meter square of the map, including oceans. This is more specific than a street address and easier to relate than coordinates while in outdoor, unnumbered spaces. The randomness of the words has a poetic sort of surprise effect to it. E.g. this location in Providence, RI where I often sneak past the cemetery wall and where this project has been dead dropped: *pens.known.rested* _ Other 3Word locations in this piece have been altered for effect.

C Shazam and the GoogleTranslate app are interesting in that they engage with sonic reality. Your device “listens”.

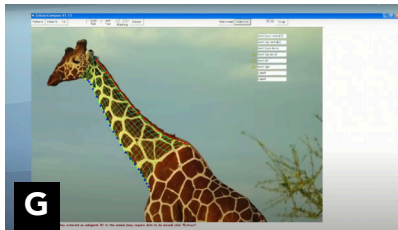
E When cloud coverage or light pollution blocks human vision from perceiving nearby constellations or celestial bodies, the NightSky app still “sees” them and displays what isn’t visible. (This the only paid app in this collection.)

* Cardiff & Miller. *Alter Bahnhof Video Walk* (2012).

APP GUIDE. (UNUSUAL INTERFACES)



F Settling into a rideshare car (ordered by app) it's fairly common to be met with another screen. Their content is simple and meant to distract (or sedate) customers. These only face the passengers visually aligned with the drivers back in a perverse Rücken-figuren.



G This giraffe identification program is used as part of a citizen science project. Asking people near giraffe habitats to submit their sightings that then allow researchers to track and analyze the movements and habits of individual giraffes or their herds.



H Trail cams also track the goings-on of different creatures. There's something about trail cam night vision in that especially unsettles. Nights are more sacred-secret. After largely excommunicating animals for our daily spaces, this type of surveillance seems especially aggrievous. Trail cams capturing the night of a domestic space heighten that disorienting suspicion.



APPENDICES.

SECOND SCREEN GESTALT.

If you're in the living room reading a book, the living room tends to disappear. If you're watching a "second screen" show while scrolling on your phone, you might hear a character announce "I'm going into the living room", rather than moving without narration - because the networks know we do this and anticipate a divided attention.

A cacophony of information marks the post(post?) modern aesthetic: multiple streams, competing focal points. The central stability, or pattern, that perception commands, might be in the format. The most readily available factor is the screen itself - a boundary shaping a shrunken reality against ambient life.

Shape might be able to suggest a group by similarity, but the laptop/TV generally sits horizontally, like a landscape. The second screen (phone) is typically held vertical, like a body. The different shapes hint at different affiliations: environment or self. Proximity sharpens this split. The phone, held close, becomes prosthetic, part of the personal umwelt. The television, across the room, becomes part of the background environment until summoned into focus. We can only see figure *or* ground. Usually, the phone relegates the world to background.

Augmented reality apps provide a window into the world, or at least its simulacrum.

Video chapters of *The Field Guide* make different attempts to bundle screens together. For example, in *Chapter 1*, the second screen and the scene of which it is part form an on-screen collage. For the viewer, the embodied relationship to the phone is merely simulated, a visual surrogate. The thumb twitch may or may not subside if the phantom limb is present in this illusion of interfaces.

When continuity struggles, closure is left to rely on expectation or cliché. Distant, unaligned rectangles create a stangely perceived whole when we flicker back and forth. It's so nebulous it might actually be a void. This is a moment where I'm most likely to tell you "I'm doing nothing". Some configurations cause disappearances. *The Field Guide* captures this with visual reminders of what is not there, and what can disappear at the edges (in fading images and use of the transparency grid).

In Gestalt formation, a figure forms against a background and, once experienced as meaningful, itself sinks back into the dark sea, to make room for a new figure to emerge. In the videos of *The Field Guide*, the assemblage of first and second screen forms and dissolves with the ebb and flow of the narrative and its language - smoothing out when the narration slows.

RABBIT HOLE / SECRET PASSAGEWAY

Any interface is a tool that directs its own use while still allowing for multiple types of interaction. This power of direction isn't always so apparent, though it is always designed in.

This can change the tempo of use, for instance, if a platform rewards fast moves (e.g. early access, "streaks", "leaderboards", or dings). You fall down a rabbit hole. The logic is centrifugal — pulling you away from any original point of contact, but everything feels uniformly urgent. . The rabbit hole never did lead Alice to a coherent world.

New media can make everything feel urgent, as if the urgency is normal. There is no obvious resting point for perception. Instead, we can disappear ourselves sweetly within the interfaces, keeping the 2025 mind comfortably occupied, if shallowly engaged. Rarely, if ever, is narrative as fast moving.

There is a tension in *The Field Guide*, video chapters display second (or third) screen visuals while the narrative moves slower, more sensually. Text chapters read faster, with more information, but keep to black and white. While moving back and forth, there should still be a connecting thread that suggests

continuity; a secret passageway, a fluid logic connecting seemingly disjointed spaces.

The ocean in this story is the medium, as the waves of the project's media collage settle and ebb. The ocean is an interface where *vision* flickers its polysemy: perception, apparition. For Anna, the vision of the giraffe destabilizes and defamiliarizes the very act of seeing. She plays at other visual games too - tricking her perception to feel the change it effects. In *The Field Guide* videos, the double-screened visual (sometimes with a illusion of embodiment, the phantom lmb appearing on screen) wants a similar effect - make the second screen strange and we can reconfigure more intentionally.

New media moves fast - technologically and phenomenologically. History is slower - like travel by ocean. A secret passageway requires pause, an attunement to texture and detail. If the rabbit hole is disorienting in a chaotic sense, the secret passage unmoors with mystery and offers a thread: the sense of something hidden but knowable.

Here, the transparency grid plays an important role as a visual reminder of this kind of liminal space, marked by digital expectation or potential.

SEEMS REAL.

IS REAL.

IS FICTION.

SEEMS LIKE FICTION.

Giraffes

